

The device

The N900 is a rectangular brick with the dimensions 110.9×59.8×18 (19.55 at the thickest part) mm that weighs approx 180 grams. The front of the device only has the screen—an 89 mm (3.5-inch) touch-sensitive resistive widescreen display with 800×480 pixel resolution. And the landscape should be your default view, rather than portrait that we've come to expect from all phone-like devices. Well, the N900 is a tablet first, anyway.

Holding it in a landscape position, you have a few things on the extreme left side of the N900's front. There's a light sensor, a VGA camera (for video conferencing), proximity sensor, earpiece and the indicator light. But no physical buttons (not even one to take calls) that we expect in phones.

On the top you have the volume slider, the power button, and the camera button. Flip to its right, and you get one of the stereo speakers, the lock/unload key and the 3.5-mm headset jack. You also have the stylus nicely tucked inside at the bottom—a very convenient position I'd say, since you'd generally want to take it out using your right hand. On the left, you have the second speaker, the mini USB port, that doubles up as a charging point too. I would have preferred a standard mini USB port, so that we could make use of regular mini USB cables to connect the device to a computer.

The three-row keyboard slides out from the bottom. The keys are slightly raised so that you can comfortably use the keyboard without looking at keys, once you're used to the location of all the alphabets and special characters. These special characters are placed at

▼ Carl Zeiss 5 MP camera lens



weird locations I must say, but that's quite natural for a portable device. And I'd say Nokia has done a good job in designing this keyboard layout.

The back side of the phone has the 5MP camera, which is protected by a lens cover. Open the cover, and you'll find a dual-LED flash next to the lens. Around the lens cover is the N900's stand.

The device is powered by an OMAP 3430 (ARM Cortex-A8) 600 MHz processor, PowerVR SGX with OpenGL ES 2.0 support for graphics, and 256MB of physical RAM (plus 768 MB virtual memory). It comes with a 1350mAh battery and 32 GB storage (which you can expand by up to 16 GB by hot-swapping a microSD card).

Other accessories include a headset (which I found not really comfortable to wear, but has good sound quality and output), a USB cable, a charger and a video out cable. And of course, there's a manual and a cleaning cloth, too. Nice! Well, here's the complete spec sheet: <http://maemo.nokia.com/n900/specifications/>

Overall, the device looks nice and rugged, and a bit on the heavier side—not at all sleek like the iPhone or the Nexus One. But, heck, it's more like a power device, than just a smartphone. And the looks, I'd add, are a must for the geek who uses it.

Besides, there's a complete GNU/Linux distro that powers the device, and not just a Linux kernel and a few libraries to support a JVM.

Getting started with a flash

Okay, let's put it this way: I didn't like the fact that I was stuck with an older version of Maemo [Version 2.2009.47-23.002] when an update was released on January 14 [Version: 2.2009.51-1; details at: http://wiki.maemo.org/Maemo_5/PR1.1]. It's supposed to work over the air, as in the package repository should have notified me—which didn't happen. Upon refreshing the repository multiple times it would still inform of no updates. So, I headed straight to download the firmware and flashed the N900. Details on how to do it are here: http://wiki.maemo.org/Updating_the_firmware.

The best part about flashing the device was, it was a piece of cake using a Linux desktop also. I'm so glad that, for once, something didn't force me to use a PC Suite that only works on that OS-that-shall-not-be-named. The whole process took hardly a few minutes, and I was back on track.

 **Note:** The reason the update didn't happen over the air could be attributed to a fact that I'll explain later.